

04

Finding Your Angle

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What Is an Angle?

An angle is the **big idea** your ad leads with — the specific doorway through which the reader enters your story. It is not the product, and it is not the benefit. The same product with the same benefit can be introduced through a dozen different doorways, and which doorway you pick usually matters more than any wordsmithing you do afterward.

All marketing is storytelling, and a funnel tells one story: the ad is the beginning, the middle page is the middle, and the sales page or video is the end. The angle is how all the elements of the ad work together to *start* that story. Get the angle right and everything downstream gets easier — the click is qualified, the middle page has a narrative to continue, the close feels inevitable. Get it wrong and no amount of headline polish will save you: you're polishing a doorway to a room the reader never wanted to enter.

This is why experienced media buyers say the magic isn't in the image, the platform, or the bid strategy. The magic is in the angle.

Brainstorming the Nugget: "What Do People With Feet, Do?"

Before you can pick an angle, you need raw material — the small, concrete, everyday truths about your audience that an angle can hook into. There's a wonderfully silly brainstorming question from the angle-hunting tradition that captures the method:

"What do people with feet, do?"

They walk. They stand all day at work. They get sore heels. They buy shoes that wear out. They kick off those shoes with a sigh at 6 p.m. They notice cold floors in winter. Every one of those humdrum behaviors is a potential hook, because every one of them is a moment your reader actually lives.

The question generalizes: whatever your product touches, ask *what do people with [that thing] actually do all day?* People with lawns mow, water, glare at brown patches, and silently compete with the neighbor. People with power bills open the envelope wincing. People with desk jobs shift in their chairs every twenty minutes. Angles built on observed

behavior land as recognition — "that's me" — which is the strongest possible opening note for cold traffic. Angles built on marketing abstractions ("optimize your comfort!") land as advertising, and get filtered out.

Collect these nuggets before writing anything. The best angle is usually sitting inside the most ordinary behavior on your list.

The Six Angle Families

Nearly every winning ad angle belongs to one of six families. Learn them as lenses: point each one at your product and see what it shows you.

1. Story. A named or relatable person's transformation, told as narrative. "Frustrated [ordinary person] discovers [path], now [result]." Story angles work because humans are wired to finish narratives, and because a protagonist absorbs skepticism — the reader isn't being promised anything; they're just hearing what happened to someone else.

2. Warning. Lead with a mistake, a hidden danger, or a loss to avoid. "The mistake [audience] make with [subject]" or "Warning signs your [thing] is failing." We fear losing more than we love gaining, and a warning frames the click as protective, not indulgent. Warning angles also read as public-service content, which suits editorial placements.

3. Discovery / News. Frame the product's mechanism as a new finding: "New [method] changes how [audience] handle [problem]." Newness answers "why am I only hearing about this now?" and gives the reader permission to hope again after past failures — *this one is different because it's new*.

4. Contrarian. Attack the conventional wisdom: "Everything you've been told about [subject] is backwards" or "[Common practice] is dead." Contrarian angles create instant tension with what the reader believes, and they flatter the reader as someone smart enough to hear the real story. They also *justify past failure* — "the standard advice was the problem, not you" — which unlocks readers who've given up.

5. Local. Anchor the story in the reader's own geography: "[City] locals are switching to..." Local angles borrow the trust of community news and sharpen relevance — the story didn't happen to someone in the abstract; it happened *here*. (Modern ad platforms can insert the reader's region dynamically, which is why this family thrives in native feeds.)

6. Unique Mechanism. Lead with the how itself: the named method, ingredient, or process (see **Curiosity: Withholding the How**). "The '3-Point Support Method' easing desk-worker back ache." Best when your audience has already tried the obvious solutions — the mechanism *is* the news.

These families combine freely: "Brisbane local Jane Mathews stumbles across a natural arthritis relief solution" is Local + Story + Discovery in a single line.

Matching the Angle to Audience Awareness

Which family should you lead with? The biggest input is your reader's **stage of awareness** — how much they already know about their problem and its solutions.

- **Unaware / problem-unaware readers** don't yet feel the problem sharply. Warning and Story angles work best: a warning surfaces a pain they hadn't named; a story lets them recognize themselves in someone else before any pitch begins.
- **Problem-aware readers** know the pain but not the solutions. Discovery/News angles shine here — they've been waiting for exactly this headline: *there's finally something for this*.
- **Solution-aware readers** know the category and have probably tried things that failed. Unique Mechanism and Contrarian angles win: the mechanism explains why this attempt will end differently, and the contrarian frame explains why the previous ones didn't.
- **Product-aware and skeptical readers** respond to proof-heavy Story and Local angles — specific people, specific places, specific numbers (see **Believability and Proof**).

The selection process in practice: list your nuggets, note your audience's dominant awareness stage, shortlist the two or three families that fit that stage, and draft headlines in each. The families are cheap to try on paper — the expensive mistake is committing your whole funnel to the first angle you thought of.

Three Classic Swipes, Annotated

SWIPE

"Brisbane Local Jane Mathews Stumbles Across A Natural Arthritis Relief Solution"

ANATOMY [Geographic Anchor] + [Named Everywoman] + [Accidental Discovery] + [Benefit Category].

WHY IT WORKS Three families stacked — Local (Brisbane), Story (Jane, a specific person), Discovery ("stumbles across," which removes sales intent: she wasn't selling anything, she just *found* it). Reads like community news, not advertising.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — the local-news register is built for a native feed.

SWIPE

"They Laughed When I Sat Down at the Piano — But When I Started to Play!" (a famous 1920s ad)

ANATOMY [Social Humiliation] + [Pivot Dash] + [Implied Triumph].

WHY IT WORKS Perhaps the most imitated story angle ever written. It compresses a complete transformation arc into one sentence and stops at the exact peak of the turn, forcing the reader into the copy to see the ending. The reader isn't buying piano lessons; they're buying the moment the laughter stops.

FUNNEL FIT Advertorial — it's the first line of a story the page then tells in full.

SWIPE

"Small Company's New Golf Ball Flies Too Far; Could Obsolete Many Golf Courses" (a famous classic)

ANATOMY [Underdog Source] + [Benefit Disguised as a Problem] + [Absurd Institutional Consequence].

WHY IT WORKS Discovery + Contrarian in one line. The benefit (distance) is framed as *too much of a good thing* — a complaint — which flips the sales pitch into news and makes the claim feel like a leak rather than an ad.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — the news register and the "wait, what?" flip are engineered for cold scrollers.

Fictional Before/After: One Product, Three Angles

Take a fictional home water filter, the ClearSpring. Same product, same core benefit — pushed through three different doorways:

Warning angle:

What's Actually In Your Tap Water? The Report Most Homeowners Never See

Story angle:

A Retired Plumber Refused to Drink His Own Tap Water — Until He Built This Simple Filter

Local angle:

Why Households Across [Your Region] Are Quietly Switching How They Drink Tap Water

Each headline would attract a different reader in a different state of mind, hand a different story to the middle page, and produce different economics — and you cannot know which wins from your desk. That's what testing is for. The craft is generating genuinely *different* doorways, not three rewordings of one.

■ Calibrating the Angle Across the Three Surfaces

An angle is not just an ad trick — it's the through-line of the whole funnel, and each surface plays a different part of it.

- **Ad — angle discovery.** The reader *meets* the angle: the warning is raised, the story begins, the discovery is announced. The ad's only job is to make this doorway irresistible to walk through.
- **Advertorial — angle proof.** The middle page substantiates the angle it inherited: the warning gets evidence, the story gets its full arc, the mechanism gets its explanation. Changing angles mid-funnel — clicking a warning and landing on an unrelated cheerful story — breaks the scent and bleeds readers.
- **Jump page — angle payoff.** The angle resolves into the promise at full intensity, pointed at the play button: the danger now avoidable, the transformation now available, the discovery now watchable.

One angle, told in three acts — never three different angles taped together.

✓ Key Takeaways

- The angle is the big idea your ad leads with — the doorway into the story. It matters more than wordsmithing.
- Brainstorm from observed behavior ("what do people with feet, do?") — angles built on real everyday moments land as recognition, not advertising.
- Learn the six families: **Story, Warning, Discovery/News, Contrarian, Local, Unique Mechanism** — and stack them freely.

- Match the family to the reader's awareness stage: warnings and stories for the unaware, discovery for the problem-aware, mechanism and contrarian for the burned-and-skeptical.
- Generate genuinely different angles before testing; three rewordings of one idea is not a test.
- The angle runs the whole funnel: discovered at the ad, proven at the advertorial, paid off at the jump page.